posts and infrastructure for transport and communications as well as alleviating the neglect of the area and its residents. But there were limits, Bajpai stressed to Henderson, to what India could do militarily.[187] Therefore, to key decisionmakers in Delhi, the missing buffer made it more necessary to keep China in good humor.[188]

The American embassy in Delhi remained concerned that Tibet would be "lost by default," and that China could "constantly menace" India from there.[189] The chargé argued that the US should convince India that the Sino-Tibetan treaty was not in its interests and that Delhi should encourage the Dalai Lama to reject it and flee to India.[190]

But, while Washington was willing to encourage Tibet's leaders and its autonomy in spirit, it was unwilling to act alone to provide military or financial assistance or appoint official representatives to Tibet. Acheson maintained that India had the primary responsibility to help Tibet.[191] In addition, the US had no desire to upset Jiang by announcing support for Tibetan sovereignty.[192] Furthermore, like Britain and India, the US was concerned about any spillover impact on the Korean situation—the reason why it would not promise a specific response to a potential Tibetan appeal to the UN.[193] Finally, any unilateral American action in Tibet would only serve to push India toward China; instead there was hope that Indian resentment would grow as the Chinese consolidated their hold over Tibet.[194]

By the fall of 1951, the Truman administration accepted that Tibetan officials were unlikely to reject the Sino-Tibetan agreement. The Far East Asia desk at the State Department advocated using "Tibet as a weapon for alerting GOI to the danger of attempting to appease any Communist Govt and, specifically, for maneuvering GOI into a position where it will voluntarily adopt a policy of firmly resisting Chinese Communist pressure in south and east Asia."[195] There were still some attempts to get India to assure the Dalai Lama that he would be given asylum. But with Delhi unwilling to take the initiative and a new US ambassador in Delhi—Chester Bowles—who was less enthusiastic about pressuring India on this issue, such efforts faded. So did hope that India would change its China policy.

Chinese Intervention in the Korean War: The Blame Game (1950–1951)